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NAYA PAKISTAN, PURANA LALA

I COULDN'T vote in 2018. I tried to make my schedules work but couldn't make it back to Pakistan in time. I regret missing out.

The 2018 elections in Pakistan were a landmark one. A cricketer is now the prime minister of the world's sixth most populous country. Unfortunately, these elections came with some serious baggage. A narrative that continues to do the rounds is that the polls were not fair. I feel the jury is out on that one: it was a 50:50 thing.

But here's a fact: Imran Khan is now the elected prime minister of Pakistan. We have to give him the respect that a prime minister deserves. We have to make things work.

That's where the media comes in. The role of the media will be essential in the coming years. For the sake of the future of Pakistan, the media must pull up its socks. It must ensure that our local governance is in order, that the government is accountable to the people of the Pakistan and that our reputation, globally, improves for the right reasons.

As for his vision, I don't have any doubts about Imran's integrity or the goals he has set to achieve – a vision that he calls 'Naya Pakistan', the new Pakistan.

The real question which bothers me, though, is his team selection. Sure, he has read the pitch, but is Imran doing what he was most famous for on the cricket field – putting the right man in the right job?

If he succeeds, his goals are so lofty that no doubt he will turn Pakistan's fortunes around. But the way I'm seeing things develop, he's restarting things from scratch. He's putting a lot of pressure on himself. He's on a long-term timeline. From debt to corruption – our two main challenges – he's got a revolutionary but a difficult-to-implement plan.

No doubt, he has created a new self-awareness in Pakistan's polity. I know, commenting about the prime minister is easier said than done. But there's no doubt in my mind that Khan's *niyat*, intention, is fine. His ability to execute – rather, his team's ability – is what bothers me.

I'm a big fan of what Khan's Naya Pakistan is doing with India. From his peace overtures (I